Mom Got Medicaid. Now What?

A plain-English guide to what comes after approval.

For months the goal was getting Mom approved. Now she is, and the envelopes from the Medicaid agency are still arriving. It would be easy to assume the process is finished, and nobody has told you otherwise.

This guide explains, in general terms, what tends to continue after an approval: letters, renewals, and changes in Mom's life that are worth writing down and asking about. It can't tell you what Mom's state requires or when. That comes from her own letters, the Medicaid agency and your Medicaid planner.

Approval is a milestone, and the letters continue

Approval comes in writing. The federal booklet Medicaid: Getting Started says a state that approves a person for coverage sends an approval letter. After it, the state keeps writing: the federal renewal flyer says the state mails a letter about a person's coverage, and that the letter says whether a form has to be completed or other information sent. [1] [2]

Medicaid is a joint federal and state program. Within broad federal guidelines, each state decides how to run its own, including who qualifies and what is covered. The same booklet adds that states have special rules for people who live in nursing homes. That is why this guide can describe the kinds of things that continue and can't give you Mom's list. [1]

- Copy down the date on the approval letter and every date it mentions, including the one it calls the effective date, in the letter's own words.
- If the letter names anything the family is to keep doing, sending or paying, copy that down too, and ask the Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner to go through it with you.

Renewals: the state looks again

A renewal is the state reviewing a person's information to decide whether they still qualify. States are required to do this through periodic renewals, and the sources below use the word redetermination for the same review. [2] [3]

The state starts it, by letter. A practice tip written for advocates by the National Center on Law and Elder Rights explains that states are meant to use the data they already have first, and to send renewal forms and requests for documents when that isn't enough. The person then fills out the forms and provides income and asset information. [2] [4]

If a renewal letter says a person is still eligible, the federal flyer says there is nothing else to do for that renewal. If it asks for more information, the flyer's advice is to send it as soon as possible, and to fill out and return a renewal form if one comes. Its first step comes before any of that: make sure the state has a current mailing address, phone number and email, so it can reach you. [2]

One habit helps with all of it: keep a copy of whatever you send, with the date. The same practice tip suggests asking the agency to stamp the received date on forms or documents handed in. [4]

- When Mom's next renewal is, and what the agency will ask for, are questions for the Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner. This guide can't give a schedule.
- Put any date a letter gives on a calendar, with a note of which letter it came from.

When something changes

The application described Mom's situation at one moment, and life continues after it. The nonprofit Justice in Aging notes that changes such as moving, retiring or a rise in income can change a person's Medicaid eligibility. It also notes that states must have procedures for people on Medicaid to report changes in circumstances that may affect their eligibility, and that states are required to handle a change using procedures meant to keep eligible people covered. [3]

Which changes Mom's agency wants to hear about, how, and by when is not something a general guide can say. It depends on the state and on her case, and it comes from her own notices and from the agency. The Medicaid Planning Roadmap's list of things to keep an eye on is short: Mom's income, her accounts and other assets, where she lives, her marital status where that applies, and her care setting.

Unexpected money gets a line of its own: an inheritance, a gift, the proceeds of a property sale, an insurance payment. This guide gives no rule for how any of it is treated. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money says only that Medicaid is complicated, and to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility. [5]

- Write each change as a plain fact with a date: what happened, when, and who told you.
- Bring the list to the Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner and ask which items need to be reported, and how.
- If money has arrived, or a gift, a sale or a transfer is being considered, ask your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney before anything is done.

A simple system: a folder, a calendar and a record

Keeping up with Medicaid is mostly keeping track. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau lists keeping good records among the basic duties of anyone managing another person's money: a list of what is received and spent with amounts, dates and reasons, and receipts and notes even for small expenses. It also suggests reviewing bank and other financial statements promptly. [5]

The Bureau's page on planning for illness adds that important documents belong in a safe, easily accessible place, with a trusted family member told where to find them, and that contact details for the professionals involved are worth keeping handy. [6]

For this step that comes to one folder for the Medicaid mail, one calendar for the dates in it, a running record of Mom's money, a list of who to call, and a time now and then to look it all over. The roadmap calls the finished version a Medicaid Maintenance Plan, and it is put together with your Medicaid planner.

What this means for your family

- The application is behind you. What continues is a routine: open the mail, keep the dates, write down what changes, ask before acting.
- Mom's own letters are the authority on her dates and requirements. A general guide isn't, and neither is another family's experience in another state.
- Your part is to save, write down and ask. Saying what has to be reported, or what a change means, belongs to the Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner.
- Legal questions, and any decision about property or a legal document, go to an elder law attorney.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what the rule is in Mom's state, what has to be reported or when, whether any change affects her eligibility, or what to do with money or property. Nothing in it is legal, financial or tax advice. The general statements come from the sources below. The list of things to keep an eye on is the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own, and the advice about what to write down is ours.

Ready for the next step?

You understand in general what continues after an approval, and what to look for in Mom's own letters. The planning interview is where it becomes about your family: it asks about your situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner, or to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (Medicare.gov publication, CMS Product No. 11409, April 2026), Medicaid: Getting Started
2. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
3. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
4. National Center on Law and Elder Rights (Administration for Community Living), Responding to Common Medicaid Unwinding Issues for Dual Eligibles
5. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
6. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness